A BRIEF NOTE ON

THE LIBERATION TIGERS OF TAMIL EELAM (LTTE)

THE LIBERATION TIGERS OF TAMIL EELAM (LTTE) WAS A MILITANT separatist organization fighting to attain a proposed independent state (the Tamil Eelam) spread across the north and east of Sri Lanka. The group was founded by Sri Lankan Tamil guerrilla Velupillai Prabhakaran on 5 May 1976 and was active until Prabhakaran's death at the hands of the Sri Lankan armed forces on 18 May 009.

The genesis of the LTTE can be attributed to discriminatory state policies and oppression of the minority Sri Lankan Tamils at the hands of the majority Sinhalese, which often included island-wide ethnic riots. The 1956 anti-Tamil pogrom in Gal Oya Valley and the 1958 riots in Ceylon led to inter-community polarization. The conflict escalated when, in 1971, the policy of standardization was introduced by the government to curtail the enrolment of Tamil students in certain universities across the nation. The Tamil diaspora, united under Prabhakaran's leadership, and the LTTE rose to prominence after defeating many insurgent Tamil militant groups. Prabhakaran reportedly believed that the LTTE was the only Tamil militant group truly dedicated to armed struggle while perceiving the others as likely to give in to political rhetoric.[1] The LTTE had its own military wing, which included an intelligence wing, a navy, an airborne unit and a specialized attack unit. Apart from following a strict code of moral conduct and undertaking gruelling military training, it was mandatory for LTTE cadres to read specialized literature and view LTTE films.[2]